

One, two, three, four. One, two, three, four. One, two, three, four. One, two, three, four. One, two, three, four. One, two, three, four. By now, maybe you skipped most of that because you couldn't imagine the purpose of it or you thought it must be some kind of mistake. Or, maybe you trusted the book enough to read each number, which allowed a rhythmic pattern to enter your head. The repetition forces you to stop *reading* and

start recognizing the shape of the words. It's similar to speed-reading. Your mind forms a flow, and after a few counts you begin to say the phrase, "one, two, three, four," the same way each time.

Once the flow is formed, it's hard to break unless you give it a different flow. I used the word "rhythmic" earlier. Please note there

is a major difference between pacing and rhythm of a film, as I use the terms in this book. Pacing is the timing of cuts, the topic of this chapter. Rhythm is the flow and separation of the overall story, which is covered in Chapter 5.

The purpose of the one, two, three, four count is to show you the foundation of what pacing actually is in a film. The four principles of pacing are:

1. Pattern
2. Symmetry
3. Flow
4. Timing

Pacing is your single most important editing philosophy and is the hardest to grasp. I could sit side by side with you for a year and you still might not master it. The key to pacing is to understand the difference between good pacing and bad pacing. Mastering pacing is something you should strive for, but there will never be a day when it comes to you automatically. At times you may be sharp, and at other times you may be sloppy, but you are generally never going to be perfect.

*Mastering pacing is something you should strive for.*

## Defining Pacing

Pacing is an abstract concept that takes practice, practice, and more practice. But don't get frustrated. I'm working on a music video right now and I had to recut it three times until I felt the pacing was right. That's the nature of editing. The important thing is that I knew the first two cuts were not paced well and that the third cut was right. I knew when to keep going—and when to stop. That's what you need to understand about pacing.

The biggest misconception about pacing is that it has anything to do with speed (fast cuts or scenes) or time (length). It's often assumed that the faster something is edited, the better the pacing is. Wrong, wrong, and more degrees of wrong. Something that is cut fast can be perfectly paced. Something that's cut extremely slow can be perfectly paced.

## Pacing Examples: Slow and Fast

A lot of great editors believe pacing is managing and utilizing the *space* in a scene—*space* meaning dead air. Some of the greatest examples of pacing come from Quentin Tarantino. The pacing of the conversations in his films really sets the bar for pacing. An example that sticks out in my head is the basement bar scene in *Inglourious Basterds*.

For those who have not seen the film and are planning to, watch it right now because a spoiler is to follow. In the scene, British and American soldiers, who are pretending to be German, meet up with their German contact. She is a famous German actress who is playing a card game with a few Nazi officers when they arrive. When a German character recognizes that one of the British men is not German, the mission falls apart and many people die.

That scene is a masterpiece when it comes to pacing—yet the pacing is very slow. That particular scene manages the space very well. There are long pauses between lines of dialogue and it feels just right. The pacing builds intensity instead of diminishing intensity. Yes, the great writing and acting help, but the editing is a crucial element. In fact, the editing may be the key ingredient to making that scene, and all scenes like it, the masterpiece it is. It comes back to what I said in Chapter 1 about the viewer anticipating what will happen. In this scene in particular, the viewer has a pretty clear understanding of what's going to happen, and the long pauses in the dialogue allow them to relish the anticipation of the predicted outcome.

Pacing ties directly into story arc and conflict. You'll notice in that scene that the back-and-forth dialogue gets *slower* as the scene goes on. What's happening is that the scene gets slower as the outcome becomes clearer. Tarantino uses anticipation as a means to manage the dead air in the scene. The pacing gives you plenty of time to anticipate the many possible outcomes of the scene.

Pacing can—and often does—change. The pacing of a particular scene is for that scene only. Pacing is a situational concept, which is why there are no magic bullet points for getting it right.

A 10-minute dialogue scene in *The Social Network* also takes place in a bar, but it couldn't be more different from the *Inglourious Basterds* scene. In *The Social Network*, it's very fast. And it, too, is a masterful example of the art of pacing. This film, by the way, won the Academy Award for Best Film Editing.

## Pacing and Effects on the Viewer

The speed of these two example scenes may be very different—one fast, one slow—but both are paced perfectly. Pacing is situational. It's based on the desired feel, mood, or outcome, and is an ever-changing phenomenon. There is no set rule. It's not as if drama is paced this way and comedy is paced that way. There certainly are trends (which I discuss later), but no rules. A scene may start out fast paced and yet slow down right in the middle.

I have formulated an equation (discussed later in this chapter) that may help you determine the proper pace at any given time. But first, you need to learn the importance of *feeling* the right pace. Most of the time it comes down to feeling and instinct. Consider a heart-rate monitor. Slow indicates tension, fast means intensity or action, and normal means, well, normal.

### SLOW PACING

A slow heart rate represents things like tension or anticipation. Beep ... beep ... beep. Those long spaces give you time to think. What's happening? When will the next beep come? *Will* the next beep come? Relate those beeps to the scene in *Inglourious Basterds* and the dramatic pauses between lines. You have time to anticipate. You have time to let your mind wonder about the possibilities. You can feel the tension in the room.

The slow heart rate can fall on the totally opposite end of the emotional spectrum as well. You can also relate romance to a slow heart rate and rely on the very nature of being in the moment to create that pace. Picture a couple lying in bed with dim lighting. They're laughing, giggling, and talking about their future together. The long

spaces between their lines can let you project yourself into their moment, or think of a moment that was similar in your life. The slow pacing is a good calling card for romance because it allows the viewer to really feel what's happening in the scene.

## FAST PACING

A fast heart rate represents action or intensity. Beep beep beep beep beep gives you no time to think; you're just perceiving the storyline at an alarming rate. A great action scene or otherwise intense scene should actually raise the viewer's heart rate.

My best friend is a neuroscientist who loves nothing more than a good experiment. We did a little testing of our own and discovered that the way a film is edited has physical effects on the viewer. We found the effects to be most apparent during action sequences. We monitored the heart rate of several subjects in three age groups, all with similar health histories. (Apparently, that matters in a scientific study—which is why I needed my friend or else I would have just used random people.) We had them all watch the same movies in the same environment and noticed a spike in heart rate during the action sequences. The spike was relatively substantial—an average increase in heart rate of 9 percent. It wasn't on the level of a workout, but there was a common spike among them all at the same point in the film. That may not seem like a lot, but if you consider that the subjects were sitting in chairs and not doing any physical activity, it's pretty impressive.

Then we showed them all an action sequence from a different film, out of context, and nothing happened. That suggests that context, or the lead-in, matters for emotional investment. And then we did a third test: We showed one test group an action sequence with poor pacing and we showed another test group the action sequence with perfecting pacing. The results were amazing. The viewers who watched the film with proper pacing had the physical response. The ones who watched the film with improper pacing showed no spike in heart rate whatsoever. It was a fascinating test, and one day I hope to do a real study and publish the data. But for now, my point is this: Pacing affects the viewer physically. And note that the lead-in to scenes also has an effect on how successful certain moments will be.

*Pacing affects the viewer physically.*

Fast-paced scenes should keep viewers on the edge of their seat. There are different levels of fast. There is fast dialogue cutting, and then there is *car-chase-like* action. Obviously the action sequence with no dialogue, or limited dialogue, will be much faster, but keep the heart rate monitor in your mind. For the sake of argument, let's

say that a fast cutting dialogue scene would hit 90 on a heart rate monitor, and an action sequence would range from 120 to 150. (Please note that these rates represent our scaled measurement, not a viewer's actual heart rate. Just know that the viewer's heart will be beating a little faster than normal.)

## NORMAL PACING

Normal is the constant in the equation. Normal equals nothing—no drama. Normal is your normal heart rate in everyday life. Normal is you getting dressed. Normal is you eating breakfast. Normal is important because when something not normal occurs, you recognize it. Normal is the gray area between black and white. A good film is normal much of the time. It's the flat parts of the rollercoaster between the ups and downs.

This is why pacing changes all the time. Let's say Jenny is outside working in the garden, minding her own business (normal). We hear a child screaming from inside the house, and Jenny pauses to listen. (At this point, the slow heart rate amplifies the anticipation.) Then the scream happens again, and Jenny runs inside and finds a burglar robbing the house. (Fast heart rate.) That one scene could take you through a spectrum of emotions and heart rates, and the pacing (timing of cuts) should match each part of the scene.

Now that you have a general idea of what pacing is, it's time to break down the principles of pacing.

# Principles of Pacing

Remember the four key elements of pacing: pattern, symmetry, flow, and timing. All four elements don't need to be present—or be a focal point of the timing of your cuts—all the time. However, at least one of the four elements must be present in pacing. By the time you finish this chapter, if you watch any movie, trailer, television show, music video, commercial, or even a news story, you should be able to identify one or more of these principles at play in the cutting efforts.

Are all editors working today good? No. Does everything you see on television and the movies work? No. But for the most part, you will see these principles present—and the better the film, the more you'll be able to spot. Depending on the type of film, you'll probably find one element more present than the others. For example, movies rely heavily on timing and flow, whereas music videos are very much a product of pattern and timing. Symmetry is found in movies, but it's a lot harder to spot than timing. Symmetry can take place over a grand scale in a film, while timing happens constantly.

Symmetry is very prominent in great commercials. Can something be properly paced and be missing one of these principles? Yes. But when it comes to these principles, the more the merrier.

Now, let's explore these principles one by one.

## Pattern

*Pattern* is a recurring editing style in a film that mirrors itself in key moments that require close viewer attention. A very basic example of this is the film *Any Given Sunday*. To me, it's one of the best edited films of all time and that is largely because of its pattern. The film is about football and the politics that go with the game. The editor throws the pattern in your face by cutting to a shot of the crowd each time a player forgets about politics and focuses only on the game. The editor then takes that shot of the crowd and *crossfades* it into a similar shot of the crowd from a long time ago—a time where only football mattered, and politics in the game did not. (A crossfade consists of slowly fading two images together; it is discussed in Chapter 5.) It's a *love of the game moment* that draws you in. The editor uses this pattern in key moments in the film, when big plays happen that change the course of the story. That's an extreme example of pattern—a recurring editing style that has its own meaning.

Generally, the use of pattern is rare and hard to recognize, but it can be extremely valuable. Most editors don't consider pattern to be an element of editing. They think it's just a crafty way to make the viewer pay more attention to a particular element of the story. But to me, pattern always exists in editing. The real questions are: "Are you aware of the pattern?" and "Are you in control of it?" Or are you merely a creature of habit who can't help but repeat similar editing tendencies throughout the story?

### PATTERN AND STYLE

Pattern can happen on a small scale or a large scale, and using pattern can help you develop a style. In fact, pattern is branding. Who are you as an editor or filmmaker? I have a pattern. I use the jump cut a lot (cutting to a different frame in the same clip, which is explored later in this chapter). I do it in every film I make without thinking about it. It's just something I do.

### EXAMPLE: BREAKING BAD

I discussed *Breaking Bad*'s use of the teaser in its nonlinear story approach in Chapter 3. If you haven't watched *Breaking Bad*, the show began every episode with a teaser. Six successful years of storytelling and captivating an audience, and the teaser was the pattern. The power of this pattern became very evident with the ending of episode 8, which capped the first half of Season 5, Part 1. (Eight episodes aired, and then one year later the next eight aired.) The ending of episode 8 was a flash-forward to the series finale of Season 5, Part 2, which would not air for another year. Well, during that year speculation swirled about the show and how it would end. Just Google *Breaking Bad* *ending predictions* to see the thousands of blog posts written predicting how it would end (as far as I know, not one of them was right). This was a flash-forward pattern on a grand scale.

### EXAMPLE: QUENTIN TARANTINO AND *INGLOURIOUS BASTERDS*

Another example of pattern on a slightly smaller—but still grand—scale is the masterful slow-paced scene in the basement pub in *Inglourious Basterds*. (The director, Quentin Tarantino, has his own patterns as a filmmaker. It doesn't take long to determine you're watching a Tarantino film.) The reason he can get away with this, or any of the long, drawn-out dialogue scenes in his movies, is that we know someone is going to die at the end of the scene. *Inglourious Basterds*' opening scene runs just shy of 20 minutes—the slowest opening scene I've ever experienced. Not many people can get away with showing a guy chopping wood, washing his face, walking inside, waiting for the Germans to show up, and then having a conversation in real time, and keep the audience on the edge of their seat. Tarantino conditioned us from his first film all the way to this film to know something amazing would happen to conclude this insanely slow-paced introduction. He didn't let us down either. It was a slaughter.

If you've seen any of Tarantino's films, you know this as you know the sky is blue. On a grand scale, pattern is storytelling in and of itself.

### EXAMPLE: MARTIN SCORSESE

Martin Scorsese is another pattern-oriented filmmaker. His films have the classic look of long takes (long, drawn-out shots that never cut). In every Scorsese movie there's at least one elaborate take that seems borderline unachievable by anyone else. It's his signature. He is old school in that his films aren't *overedited* (too many cuts) as a lot of films are in today's digital world. Whenever I see a long Steadicam shot of someone walking through a room with a few hundred extras, I know Scorsese is the brain is behind it.

## EXAMPLE: DAVID FINCHER AND *FIGHT CLUB*

Now, there's one filmmaker who has no signature, and that is David Fincher. I think Fincher is the best filmmaker alive, and arguably to ever live. This is because you can't always tell you're watching a Fincher film. Instead, he puts the story above everything and everyone. You can't help but respect that. For everyone else, it seems, the story is secondary to the style. They make the movie, their way, in their vision, and in their style. This is not a knock on everyone else, myself included, but praise for David Fincher for the simple fact that he doesn't repeat himself. If Fincher does have a pattern or style, it's that he focuses heavily on the pattern of the story and film he's making—and not on any overall style or preference. He creates different patterns in each of his films.

Let's talk about Fincher's movie *Fight Club*. I believe it is the greatest movie ever made. The layers go very deep, and so does the pattern. There are so many hidden patterns edited into this film that it took double-digit viewings for me to catch them all. Unless you know the story, you don't know that Edward Norton's character is talking and interacting with himself the entire film. But once you find that out and go back and watch the movie again, that fact is right in your face over and over again. The first and loudest example of that is when Edward Norton is narrating the line "If you woke up in a different time, at a different place, could you wake up as a different person?" Then a shot of Brad Pitt on an electric walkway appears. I'm not sure I noticed this shot at all the first time I watched the film because the walkway is so crowded. But now, that's the answer to the ending.

Pattern is one of the things that make this film what it is. For starters, Brad Pitt's character, Tyler Durden, flashes onscreen in a single frame several times before he appears in the film. This is not in the book *Fight Club*, which the film is adapted from. No, this is an editing decision made to reference Durden's night job as a screen projectionist, where he splices frames of inappropriate images into family films. Showing Durden himself spliced in similarly is nothing short of genius. As Edward Norton's character says, "No one knows they saw it, but they did." Pattern links those two things in the story.

Now, rewinding a bit in that scene, the film explains how Durden does this. At this point, it mentions that movies don't come all on one reel, they come on a few. And Durden's job is to change the reels in the middle of the movie. Edward Norton says, "It's called a changeover, the movie keeps on going, and no one in the audience has any idea." This is interesting because when the reveal happens during the climax of the film, he repeats the line again, and the pattern occurs. What pattern? Well, the pattern of the way he says the line, and the pacing of the scenes and shot selection

are identical. It brings home a visual familiarity that gives the viewer a subtle sense of *déjà vu*, thus enhancing the climax. The same dropout of music happens, and you see the *cigarette burns* referred to in the original scene. The patterns in this film are endless.

Another thing *Fight Club* has a lot of, related to pattern, is symmetry.

## Symmetry

Remember Chekhov's gun from Chapter 1? "If you show a gun in chapter 1, it had better fire a shot by chapter 3." That's symmetry. Editing should mirror the story's symmetry and also create its own. In the story arc, the downslope is kind of a mirror image of the upslope. It goes up to the climax, then comes down. That kind of symmetry should go as deep as you can take it into the finest detail in your film.

Remember, each scene is its own arc, too. This means each and every moment in your film is symmetrical, just like the overall story. Another word for symmetry in the context of storytelling is *balance*. You can't have light without darkness. You can't have happiness without sadness. You need to travel from one extreme to the other. The day starts dark, the sun rises in the east, and then sets in the west. What shape does that make? An arc. And during that day the arc can take us on a wild rollercoaster ride. It could rain. It could snow, sleet, or hail. It could be beautiful or gloomy. The options are endless, but balance is inevitable. There is a psychological need for balance in life and in film.

The visual serendipity of having an even balance of wide shots and close-ups has an astounding effect on viewers. This symmetry ensures you achieve the maximum amount of emotional opportunity in each viewer's mind. The wide shots balance the close-ups, and the medium shots are neutral. The more even the scale of that balance, the clearer the emotional goal becomes. Understanding this is controlling it. If you choose to tip the scales in favor of one or the other, you need to be conscious of it and know what you're accomplishing by doing so. Using more close-up shots than wide shots means you're heavily focusing on characters and their emotions. In this case, you're trying to achieve your emotional goals through expression as opposed to action. It's intense. When you favor wide shots, you're making a conscious effort to make the viewers feel as if they're a part of the scene or in the room.

If it seems like I'm explaining shot selection again, I'm not. The point here is what you're accomplishing with specific combinations of shots. First you learn one punch, and then you learn a combo. Everything in editing is intertwined. Concepts bleed onto each other. Shot selection is really about selecting the right shot at the right time; pacing is about the timing of cuts and balancing the types of shots. Symmetry, one

of the four principles of pacing, is the bridge between the concepts of shot selection and pacing. (Keep in mind that we haven't even explored the timing of cuts, which is the implementation of pacing. We're still talking about the principles.)

Let's take symmetry even deeper, remaining aware of the arc and starting with the exposition (the beginning). Let's say that when you establish your conditions in the exposition, you use a specific shot combination to introduce a concept. Jenny walks into a bar and tells the bartender about her money problems. To establish this, you approach it in a standard way: You establish the bar with a wide shot, single Jenny out with a medium, and then use the close-up when she delivers the line, "I'm broke." Then Jenny slides a twenty-dollar bill across the bar and asks for a refill. For this shot, you choose an overhead, shooting straight down on the bar, featuring the top of the two characters' heads and the money. Then you punch in close on the twenty-dollar bill. You end with a close-up of Jenny, smiling and saying, "I would spend my last dollar on this drink, I need it so bad." Jenny winks.

Your shot combination and order is crucial here. Later in the story, Jenny starts a business, makes millions, and gets married. Then she gets divorced, loses most of her money, and the movie ends with her depressed at the bar. Guess what happens next? Jenny slides a twenty-dollar bill across the bar and says, "I would spend my last dollar on this drink, I need it so bad." This is where symmetry plays a role in editing. You've conditioned the viewer to see this moment a certain way, so if you present it the same way, it will have a much bigger impact. You want the same shot order and the same shot selection. I will go as far as to say that each shot should be the same duration. Films do this all the time, and you don't even realize it.

Symmetry can happen in all kinds of ways. Repeating music, using color grades on key moments, and adding sound effects are all ways to cue the viewers to think "I've been here before." When the viewers feel something familiar, you should be accounting for that in the pacing. Sometimes a cue can come from other sources, and you may need to use the pace to cue the viewers, which means approaching pacing for the scene that it is in and not with the goal of symmetry in mind. These concepts are explored in later chapters.

**NOTE** *The key to symmetry is familiarity. When viewers are familiar with a moment as they enter it, you've accomplished a great deal in your story. It means you told them something, they remembered it, and that information helps tell your story later on. That's impactful storytelling and editing. There isn't a story in the world, good or bad, that doesn't have balance. In film, editing is one of the key ways to achieve that symmetry.*

## Flow

Ask a random filmmaker for the definition of pacing. The answer is likely to involve some sort of action. The most common response I hear is, “It just moves,” while the person snaps his or her fingers. While that is a basic understanding of pacing, what the person is really describing is a small but very important element of pacing called *flow*. It’s easier to understand flow when it’s faster, but the films that flow the best are slower. And with the slower ones, it’s harder to achieve flow.

A great way to learn flow is by editing music videos. If you are just starting out as a filmmaker and haven’t done much editing, start editing music videos. This is not because they’re the be-all and end-all of film editing, but because editing music videos can teach you some really good habits. It shows you how to cut to the music and integrate that into the editing of a film. It also can teach bad habits. Relying on cutting to the music is a crutch that can cripple your pacing, so be careful when you try to take the music video approach to any other type of narrative. (The exception is a montage, a collection of short shots edited together to condense space, time, and information, discussed in Chapter 5.)

These days, most videos don’t have much of a story. It’s sad but true. I don’t do many of them anymore. When I first started out as an editor, I did a lot of rap videos. They were basic with people rapping to the camera in five or six cool locations. I didn’t know any better, and it forced me to be a good editor. In some situations, editing is all you have to make something remotely acceptable. I believe every editor should work on at least three music videos. You can only take them so far, but it’s an exercise in flow. Because there’s no story, you usually have one speed: fast. So it flows like a river from start to finish with fast cuts all the way through. This can teach you the value of a single frame.

With a story, however, you need to take your flow and move it into storytelling. You also need to understand that a story has many different speeds. Some parts are fast and some parts are slow. Understanding the flow of the *river* is what helps you determine what cutting speed to use. The speed of the actual narrative is a good indicator of cutting speed. Whatever the speed of the story or the arc is, you want to match it. Flow means making hard choices. You may end up cutting redundant lines. You may shorten or lengthen pauses. You may take a facial expression from one part of the scene and move it to a different scene because you want to alter the speed of the cutting. You don’t edit a film exactly how it’s shot—you trim the fat and beef up the meat.

I compare the ending of scenes or moments to texting. If you're texting a friend back and forth, it could look a little something like this:

You: Hey what r u doing tonight?

Friend: Nothing, u want to get together?

You: Yeah I get off work at 6, happy hour doesn't end until 9, want to go?

Friend: Yeah let's do it, u r buying the first round.

You: OK cool. I'll have the cold beer waiting for u.

Friend: OK

That's a standard conversation. The part that drives me insane is the response "OK." Really? You wasted a whole message on that? That's how you need to treat film flow. If it doesn't move the story forward, cut it. The "OK" contributes nothing to the story. You can make the argument that it's closure to the scene. When it comes to the beginning and ending, try thinking of each scene as a piece of the bigger story. You don't need closure in every scene. A scene can just end before we, as an audience, see it end.

## GOODBYES WITH MEANING

My brother, a lawyer, asked me why people never say goodbye at the end of phone conversations on TV. They just hang up. "It's a waste of time to say goodbye. It's much quicker to hang up," I responded. It's as simple as that. Every second is valuable. Every word that isn't accomplishing something is a second your viewer could give up on you. That is why we let the viewer assume the goodbye without showing it.

Saying goodbye, however, can be a major plot point. Maybe a woman is saying goodbye to her father on his deathbed. In that case, it's an emotional goodbye that will stay with the character for the rest of the story. Here, you linger in the moment as long as you can because you're capitalizing on the emotional.

The lesson here is that it's not about the words spoken—it's about the context they're spoken in. A person saying goodbye at the end of a casual phone call doesn't compare to a woman saying goodbye to her father on his deathbed. Even if the words are the same, the context of the moment calls for a different pacing.

***TIP** One of the best things you can do as an editor is edit your scenes with this philosophy in mind: Enter in the middle of the scene and leave before it's over.*

When you enter in the middle of the moment, viewers are already playing catch-up. That gives their minds something to do. They're establishing a backstory in their minds with information you're giving them. The same thing works for the ending. Leave before it's over, and the audience gets to infer the ending with the information you gave them. This feeds the idea that the film is a collaboration between filmmaker and viewer.

Don't finalize things. Now, take this with a minor grain of salt. What I mean is every conversation in your story doesn't need to come to a complete close. Watch any movie at random and count the number of scenes that end with some sort of finalizing line (such as OK, goodbye, see you later) or a character walking out of the scene. You won't find many—or any. That's because of flow. The editor made the choice to trim the fat.

## Timing

*Timing* refers to deciding when to make a cut. Timing is the sixth sense of an editor. Knowing exactly at which frame to cut from one clip to the other is learned by experience. Experience is the key to good timing. Being able to say, "I've been here before" is the true measure of greatness. The main problem with that is that you've actually never been there before. You may have been in similar situations, but not the same.

Before becoming a filmmaker, I was a professional poker player. You might be thinking, "Wow, those careers seem vastly different." Yes, they certainly offer different lifestyles, but the mental focus, attention to detail, and importance of past experiences are quite similar. In poker, they say you'll never be in the same situation two times. It's true. The room, the cards, the money at stake, the people in the hand, the time of day, the build-up to that hand—all of those details come into play during any given hand. It's a true ripple effect. It may seem like you've been in this situation before, but it's not the same.

That's true of film as well. You'll never actually be in the same situation twice. All you can do is take each situation for what it's worth and log it into your mental library as to how such situations play out. You'll call upon your mental library in each and every decision you make. Some call that instinct, and sure, instinct plays a role. But history also plays an important role in the decision of when to cut. Being good at pacing doesn't mean being able to sit down with raw footage and make a beautifully

paced film on the first try. Pacing is about trial and error. It's about looking at a film and saying, "No, we need to start over." For quick turnarounds, same-day edits, and the like, just know that a rushed film will never reach its true potential. Edited films almost always require a period of mental processing. You shouldn't spend 12 hours editing a film and then immediately judge your work. You need some distance. You need to take time to process.

Pacing is being able to look at a film and know that it's improperly paced. Being a disciplined editor means having the patience to re-edit a film until it feels right. (You'll explore the timing of cuts later in this chapter.)

## SPOTTING CUES TO TIMING

When the word "timing" is used in the context of pacing, it's referring to using the cues as a means to cut. *Cues* can come from anywhere, but usually they come from your characters. If a character looks at something, chances are your next shot will be what he sees. It seems like the same idea as the narrative perspective, but the lag time between when the character looks at something and when you show what he sees is timing. How long you delay what the character sees will determine its emotional impact. The cue comes from the moment as well. If she looks into her wallet to see how much money is inside, holding on her face for three seconds before you show the wallet is probably not a good idea because she's just checking. However, if we as the audience know how much money she has, and she's checking her wallet to find out money has been stolen, then you would hold on her face to capture her reaction.

This ties back to the narrative perspective discussed in Chapter 3. When I talked about showing what characters see, I never specifically covered *when* or *if* they should see things.

## EXAMPLE: TIMING IN ACTION

Let's say Mary and Sally are sitting in the dining room eating dinner. The story is told from Mary's perspective. Sally asks Mary, "What time is it?" As the editor, you should show Sally asking the question. Then you show Mary looking at her watch. Do you show the actual watch? No. The only reason to show the watch is if the time of day is important to the story. In this case, Mary simply replies, "5:30." Showing the watch would be bad timing.

If several shots of the watch were filmed with the intent of using them, you may feel like you need to show the watch. But don't be distracted by what you have. Why is this a case of timing and not shot selection? Well, it's always a case of shot selection, just

as it's always a case of narrative perspective. The pacing will be destroyed if you show the shot of the watch because the viewer doesn't need a visual reference to something that doesn't matter. In short, no matter where you time the shot of the watch, it won't be timed properly. It's a shot set for failure.

Sometimes, editors get lost in the shots they have and feel like they need to use everything. Let's continue the scene. After the time is established, Mary and Sally hear a loud bang in the kitchen. Sally gets up and runs to the kitchen. She looks in the kitchen and says, "Oh no, you're not going to believe this." Mary, walking slowly behind, enters the doorway and sees broken plates on the floor.

The shot sequence and timing would be as follows: You show a shot of the two women reacting to the bang. In the same shot, Sally gets up. You show Sally reacting to what she's seeing in the kitchen, and then her line to Mary. You do *not* show what's in the kitchen at this point. That's bad timing. There are three reasons *not* to do that here:

- You've created a moment of anticipation. The viewers are asking themselves, "What is it?"
- The story is told from Mary's perspective; if she hasn't seen it yet, neither have you.
- Once you've seen what made the bang, the story is over. Everything after that doesn't matter.

Now Mary enters the doorway and reacts to what's in the kitchen. Focus on her reaction as long as possible. Then, in the frame before you feel it becomes redundant, cut to what Mary sees. That, in a nutshell, is timing.

## Timing of Cuts: The Pacing Formula

Pacing is the timing of cuts. This section helps you determine the proper timing of cuts. Don't confuse this with the concept of timing as discussed earlier. Timing is a singular moment while the timing of cuts refers to a plural concept. This means determining an average cut time through the scene. The equation you're about to learn is not an exact science—it's a guideline to help you analyze the type of pacing you need and analyze whether the pace you've created is correct. Ready? Here it is:

*Speed of Conversation + Length of Scene + Number of Characters + Drama + Mood = Pace*

Ask yourself, "What's my goal? What's the scene trying to accomplish in terms of feelings of the viewer?"

The following sections discuss these elements of the equation in detail. Remember, each one is only one element of the equation. Each part of the equation plays an equal role in determining what the pace should be.

## Speed of Conversation in a Scene

When I say the *speed of conversation*, I'm referring to an actual conversation in a scene. The conversation is the foundation for all of editing, as discussed later. (If a scene doesn't have a conversation, then substitute *scene* for *conversation*, and the scene would center on the unfolding of events.) Even in a music video, the lyrics act as a conversation. The speed of conversation means the natural speed in which characters in the scene communicate back and forth. If the scene is an argument between two characters, it would have a much faster back and forth—faster cutting—than if two characters are talking about the weather. The pacing of the scene reflects the speed of the conversation.

**OUT OF ORDER MOVIE** Take a look at timecode 1:15:19 in the *Out of Order* movie. Focus on the pacing of the scene: It starts out slow and builds throughout the scene, and then drops back to a slower pace by the end (**FIGURE 4.1**). It follows the natural flow of the conversation. However, the part you should be focusing on here is that as the speed of the conversation picks up, the cutting speed also picks up.



**FIGURE 4.1** The conversation starts slow and then speeds up.

It's best to look at the natural flow, or intended natural flow, of the conversation and use that as a basis. For example, wedding vows naturally have a slower back and forth. Usually, the vows are used as the climax of a wedding film, so you may want to find ways that the pacing is faster than the organic flow of that conversation. A trick I like to use is moving into an intercutting sequence (see Chapter 3 for more on intercutting). I use footage from other parts of the wedding, making the vows last longer but with faster cuts.

If you didn't want to interrupt the vows, you could simply use a faster cutting speed during the vows. The key is to include reaction shots from the audience in addition to the bride and groom talking. You don't always have to show the person who is talking. Once their vows are covered with B-roll, you can actually change the speed in which they talk by elongating or shortening the pauses between words.

The speed of conversation is always the first element of a scene I consider. The original intention is always the constant. You're either trying to re-create, go faster, or go slower, but the point is the original intention gives you a reference as opposed to working from an abstract idea.

***TIP** The speed of the conversation will have an effect on the average cut time. A slow conversation should average fewer cuts per second than a faster conversation.*

## Length of Scene

The *length of scene* is another indicator of pace. The following is not a rule, but a guideline: The longer the scene is, the faster the pacing should be to help sustain interest and make things feel shorter than they actually are. Unless your name is Quentin Tarantino, you're not likely to generate interest in a dialogue scene that lasts eight minutes. Generally, the longer the scene, the faster the pace should be.

Consider two guys talking about the weather. How long do you think you can get away with that before your audience turns on you? Forty-five seconds to a minute might be the longest anyone could stand a scene like that. That's not very long, but it goes hand in hand with the speed of conversation theory. If you have two guys talking about the weather, the speed of the conversation is most likely slower, and a 45-second scene matches with the slower pace. Now you should be seeing how the pieces of the equation start to align. With characters arguing, the scene could easily last two to three minutes, and it would require a faster pace.

Let me throw a monkey wrench into this situation, however. Let's say you have a two-minute scene of two characters talking about the weather, and you want it to feel properly paced. What do you do? First, hope this never happens. Second, one thing you can count on is that if a story takes two minutes to talk about the weather, then it's a very important story element. The weather may be affecting the characters' travel plans or even threatening their lives. These things lead to intensity, which in turn leads to a faster pace. That aligns with the length of your scene.

*I've yet to make a film where every scripted scene made the final cut of the movie.*

You may be thinking, "What if I have a scene with two characters talking about the weather that lasts two minutes and it's not important to the story at all?" Then your solution is easy: Cut the scene. Hard choices need to be made. I've yet to make a film where every scripted scene made the final cut of the movie. Talking about meaningless weather sounds like a great scene to cut.

## Number of Characters

The *number of characters* is another important element in the art of pacing. The more characters you have, the more vantage points you have the opportunity to show. It's a game of numbers. If you have two characters in a room talking about the weather, you're pretty limited in what you can show. Because talking about the weather doesn't generally result in an intense, fast conversation, the pacing is going to be slower. But if you have six characters in a room talking about the weather, then all of a sudden the pacing can be amplified.

**OUT OF ORDER MOVIE** Take a look at 1:04:44 in the *Out of Order* film. Two people in a room are talking. Immediately following this scene, seven people in a room are talking. Notice how the pacing drastically switches between the two scenes just because of the number of characters (**FIGURE 4.2**). The conversation isn't more intense, and the speed of the conversation hasn't changed. It comes down to more characters and their reactions. Try counting how many times it cuts to a character who isn't talking.



**FIGURE 4.2** More characters leads to a faster pace and more cutting.

Think about two people in a room talking about the weather; you'll likely have three usable shots. A wide shot, a two-shot of both characters, and a medium shot of both characters. It's unlikely that you would have a close-up of either character because using close-ups would produce a repetitive-looking scene that offers no visual stimulus. If there's no intensity in what the characters are saying, as a viewer I need the visual stimulus of wide and medium shots because the context of the moment is equal to what they're saying.

I have a theory I call "3's company" that says once you add a third person to the scene, you immediately gain an opportunity to show a significant number of shots that you couldn't have before. Let's say you add a third person to the weather conversation scene. Now you still have the original three-shot opportunities, but you also have five more to add to that list. You now have a wide three-shot of all the characters. You have a medium shot of the third character. You also have a combination of two shots showing two of the three characters. This third character offers more shots, which leads to more cuts, which leads to faster cuts, which leads to a faster pace. Here's the best part about the third person: They don't even have to talk. All they have to do is react. If they react to what's being said in the scene, then they're a part of the scene. According to the 3's company theory, the more characters you have, the more vantage points you have an opportunity to show.

## Drama and Mood

*Drama* is associated with what you want the viewers to feel. Drama is something you can control. *Mood*, on the other hand, is something the characters feel, and it's totally out of your hands. (That is up to the story.) These two concepts don't always line up—sometimes they do and sometimes they don't. Think about a comedy, for example. Physical comedy refers to pain. If a character slips and falls in a dramatic way, he's going to feel pain. The viewers won't feel pain, though—they'll just laugh. Drama is between you and the audience; mood is between the characters.

You can have three different characters in a scene who all feel different emotions, while the audience is feeling something different from all the characters. The major thing that comes into play here is the narrative perspective. If you're telling the story from a particular character's perspective, your hands are tied.

Back to the weather conversation. Three characters are in a two-minute scene talking about weather. Two of the characters are joking and the third character is scared. The viewers should associate with the funny characters. Three characters (Number of Characters) + a two-minute scene (Length of Scene) + a fast-talking conversation (Speed of Conversation) + wanting the audience to laugh (Drama) + the mixed emotions of the characters, laughter and fear (Mood) = a faster-paced scene. Almost all the elements point to a fast pace, and the point that brings it home is drama.

**TIP** Comedy tends to have a faster, poppy pace. It's not quite as fast as action, but it's faster than most genres. (Poppy refers to popcorn cutting, discussed in the next section. It just means that the cutting happens at the ends of lines. Simply put, whenever a character is talking, you can see them. This doesn't mean any genre has a particular cutting style; it's more of a current trend.)

## Types of Cuts

Many different types of cuts are available when you hit the editing board. A cut isn't just a cut, unless it's what's known as a hard cut. When choosing the type of cut to use at any given time, your decision will depend on four things: genre, length, style, and pacing. Some genres favor certain types of cuts, which are covered in the following sections.